



ISHAN TANWIA

so-called magic of the Dalit-Brahmin combination. She had a mission—and a slogan to match. She promised to destroy what she called the Goonda Raj. Neither BJP nor Congress had a slogan or a leader with a strong regional flavour. All the 206 candidates who won the election for BSP sought votes in her name and not for themselves.

Modi and Maya can now be hawked in the political market as products that provide high yields over short and long terms. They drive and decide the valuation of their respective organisations. A strong leader is like the mega brand of a multi-product company. And Modi has emerged as the star brand in the saffron flagship. Most companies are led by one strong brand, which propels the growth of other brands. This is as true of India today as it is of Ford or Mahindra. As with any party, BJP has trusted tractors, slow vans, rugged jeeps and me-too four-wheelers. Modi is the super-performer who embodies power, precision and aggression. At the moment, few products can match this SUV from the House of Saffron in political engineering—and like the Mahindra Scorpio, he elicits oohs and aahs from envious aspirants.

Once upon a time, the Congress enjoyed a similar advantage over its opponents. In the golden '80s, it could ensure a victory of even a lamp post in an election if it had a picture of Indira Gandhi hanging from it. Till 1967, it could retain almost a two-third majority in the Lok Sabha because it had a strong leadership both at the Centre and in the states. Barring Tamil Nadu, all states were ruled by the Congress. It was a time when a formidable Centre was built on a strong regional base. Nehru, and later Indira, were strengthened by such powerful regional leaders as K. Kamaraj, S. Nijalingappa, Y.B. Chavan, Pratap Singh Kairon, Mohan Lal Sukhadia, Kamalapati Tripathi, H.N. Bahuguna, V.P. Singh, K. Karunakaran, Darbara Singh, Y.S. Parmar, Chenna Reddy, Arjun Singh and D.P. Mishra. They ensured the Congress's hegemony. Threatened by the Syndicate, a paranoid Mrs G began the process of demolishing the regional leaders. The local space was promptly captured by leaders driven by caste or regional identity. So India saw the rise of Charan Singh, Mulayam and Kalyan Singh in Uttar Pradesh, Sheikh Abdullah in

SONIA AND MANMOHAN, CONGRESS VS

ADVANI AND RAJNATH SINGH, BJP

Even by the most charitable estimate, neither partnership can win more than 160 seats for their respective parties.

Jammu and Kashmir, Biju Patnaik in Orissa, N.T. Rama Rao in Andhra Pradesh, Annadurai in Tamil Nadu, Bhairon Singh Shekhawat in Rajasthan, Parkash Singh Badal in Punjab, Dev Raj Urs in Karnataka, Lalu Prasad in Bihar, Bal Thackeray and Sharad Pawar in Maharashtra.

One quality was common to all: the ability to provide an ideological product differentiation. Still, a strong leader is not necessarily a mass leader. And it is mass leaders who win elections—leaders who have the charisma to reach out to the vote bank of emotions. Nehru could do it, but Indira did it better. The mind of India was her constituency. She preserved it in spite of her totalitarian temptations. From the Right, it was Atal Bihari Vajpayee who grew larger than the party and formed an emotional covenant with the nation.

It was in the south that the magic of the regional saviour became a mass